ABOUT THE ORIGINAL STUDY

Revolving school doors? A longitudinal examination of teacher, administrator, and staff contributions to school churn

Study authors: Emily K. Penner, Yujia Liu, and Aaron J. Ainsworth

Why It Matters

Schools depend on many adults beyond teachers, yet staff turnover is rarely examined across roles. This study compares mobility and exit across Oregon's public school workforce, showing why teacher turnover alone gives an incomplete picture of school staffing instability.

Data and Sample

The study uses Oregon administrative records covering all public school employees from 2006–2007 through 2022–2023, totaling 1,273,002 person-year observations. School-context analyses use 962,738 observations of school-based employees in schools with at least five employees.

Key Findings

- Teachers were the most stable of the five broad employee groups, with average annual turnover of 17.2% over the study period. Turnover includes school or district moves and exits from Oregon public schools.
- By 2021–2022, turnover reached study-period highs for teachers (21.3%), administrators (26.1%), paraprofessionals (30.7%), and licensed staff (25.9%).
- Teacher retention in Oregon public schools was relatively stable over longer horizons, while paraprofessional and non-licensed staff retention was substantially lower and declined over time.
- Within-school turnover across employee groups was only modestly correlated. School-context patterns differed by role, and some relationships changed after accounting for other staff and school characteristics.

Policy Implications

- Consider retention needs separately for teachers, administrators, paraprofessionals, and other staff. The authors argue that different employee groups may require different policy solutions.
- Consider paraprofessionals and non-licensed staff as potential candidates for grow-your-own teacher pathways. The authors see promise in these groups' diversity and staffing patterns.
- Expand research on retention interventions and working conditions for non-teaching employees, including their employment alternatives.

Full Citation and Paper Link:
Penner, E. K., Liu, Y., & Ainsworth, A. J. (2026). Revolving school doors? A longitudinal examination of teacher, administrator, and staff contributions to school churn. *Educational Researcher, 55*(6), 376–388.
Read the full paper: https://doi.org/10.3102/0013189X261419503
Publicly available working paper (2023 version): https://edworkingpapers.com/ai23-777

Acknowledgment and Disclaimer:
This brief was produced with support from the Walton Family Foundation. The ERRE Center summarizes the original research; any errors in this summary are the responsibility of the center. The findings and interpretations presented do not necessarily reflect the views of the center or its funders. Readers should consult the original paper for complete findings and details.